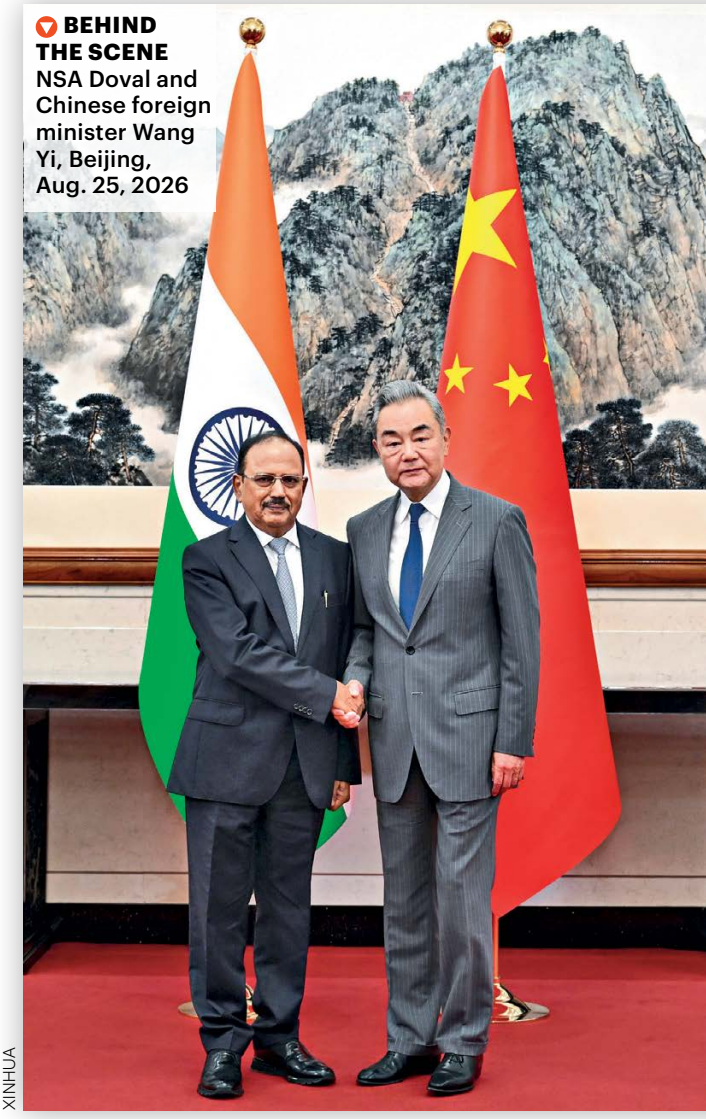
Doval and Chinese foreign minister Wang Yi, the Special Representatives for the vexed boundary question. The two concluded their 25th round of talks with an unusually detailed eight-point consensus. Much of it, on the surface, was familiar diplomatic language, but there were significant departures. Experts regard it as the most detailed public roadmap either government has issued on the boundary question in more than a decade.

AN EARLY, SUBSTANTIAL HARVEST

While both sides reiterated their commitment to "peace and tranquility" on the border based on the 2005 Political Parameters and Guiding Principles for the Settlement of the India-China Boundary Question, they pushed for "advancing negotiations" to ensure a "fair, reasonable and mutually acceptable" boundary settlement. Two key groups were tasked with discussing an "Early and Substantial Harvest" of boundary delimitation and border management. While early harvest was part of the statement in the Doval-Wang talks held in Delhi in August 2025, what has raised expectations this time is the addition of the word "substantial" in their recent statement.

The 2026 agreement also formalised the setting up of an Expert Group on Boundary Delimitation (EGBD) in addition to the Working Group on Border Management set up last year under the existing Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination (WMCC) on India China Border Affairs. To improve border management measures, two additional points for Senior Highest Military Commander (SHMC) meetings were to be set up. These are likely to be in the Eastern Sector of the LAC that stretches from Sikkim to Arunachal Pradesh and the Middle Sector that consists of disputed areas in Himachal and Uttarakhand. Currently, there is only one SHMC meeting point at Chushul-Moldo in Ladakh in the Western Sector.

The two sides also agreed to establish two additional military hotlines in the Eastern and Middle sectors. There are already six hotlines—two in the Western Sector and four in the Eastern Sector—operated at the field level between the brigade and battalion commands. The two new ones will operate at a higher level and are expected to directly connect the headquarters of India's Eastern and Central Army Command with their counterparts in the People's Liberation Army of China. Both the two new SHMC meetings and the two high-level hotlines are seen as a strategic shift to allow senior theatre commanders to swiftly communicate during multi-point standoffs at the LAC, preventing local confrontations from escalating into full-scale conflict.



XINHUA

BEHIND THE SCENE NSA Doval and Chinese foreign minister Wang Yi, Beijing, Aug. 25, 2026



"GIVEN THE CURRENT GEOPOLITICAL SITUATION, BOTH SIDES HAVE AN INTEREST IN BEING SEEN AS NOT ANTITHETICAL TO EACH OTHER"

SHYAM SARAN

Former foreign secretary

The mechanism-building measures outlined in the 2026 Doval-Wang agreement are arguably its most concrete achievement, and they read directly as an attempt to ensure that a Galwan-type conflict is not repeated. There has also been a normalisation of everyday cross-border life because of the 2025 and 2026 agreements. This includes an expanded Kailash Mansarovar Yatra, the reopened trading points at the three border passes of Shipki La in Himachal, Lipulekh in Uttarakhand and Nathu La in Sikkim. Importantly, a fresh round of the Expert-Level Mechanism on Trans-border Rivers to address hydrological data-sharing also figures in the latest agreement. This matters enormously to downstream Indian states, especially after the recent Himalayan calamity in Nepal.